Mauryan metropolis. How the king's message was received there seems to have depended on a variety of factors at the level of the locality, ranging from the character of communities to the nature of trade and commerce.

The same processes can be seen at work in Afghanistan. This was a frontier region at the edge of the Mauryan empire continuously open to influences from Greece, Iran, Central Asia, and India. Very possibly, it was through this part of his empire that several of the emissaries Ashoka would later send to sovereigns of the Hellenistic world passed.[34] Even at this point, the existence of a Greek sanctuary at Kandahar within a few yards of the emperor's edict underlines the presence of citizens who were familiar with and engaged in cult activities rooted in the classical world of the West. We have also seen that terminology locally introduced, such as eusebeia or 'piety' and qshyt or 'truth' in place of the Prakrit dhamma, exemplifies how inter-ethnic contacts resulting from those influences played a part in translating Ashoka, even if the tone and character could not have been an entirely local conception.[35] In other words, while Afghanistan marked the physical limit of the empire of Ashoka on the west, the cosmopolitan communities here were heirs to a multicultural heritage independent of the Mauryas, and one which, historically speaking, is not evoked in descriptions that see this region as peripheral.

It has been suggested that the Kandahar edict has less in common with other minor rock edicts while showing a general concordance with another edict of Ashoka, Rock Edict IV, in which a similar sense of prior ethical accomplishment is conveyed. The concordance can only be general because Rock Edict IV is a far more elaborate statement within which the obedience that is exhorted in the Kandahar edict figures in only one of its sentences. What further complicates the question of such a link is that Rock Edict IV came into being two years after the one at Kandahar. So, because of the chronology, not much is gained by trying to locate the genealogy of the first Afghan edict in other royal rescripts.